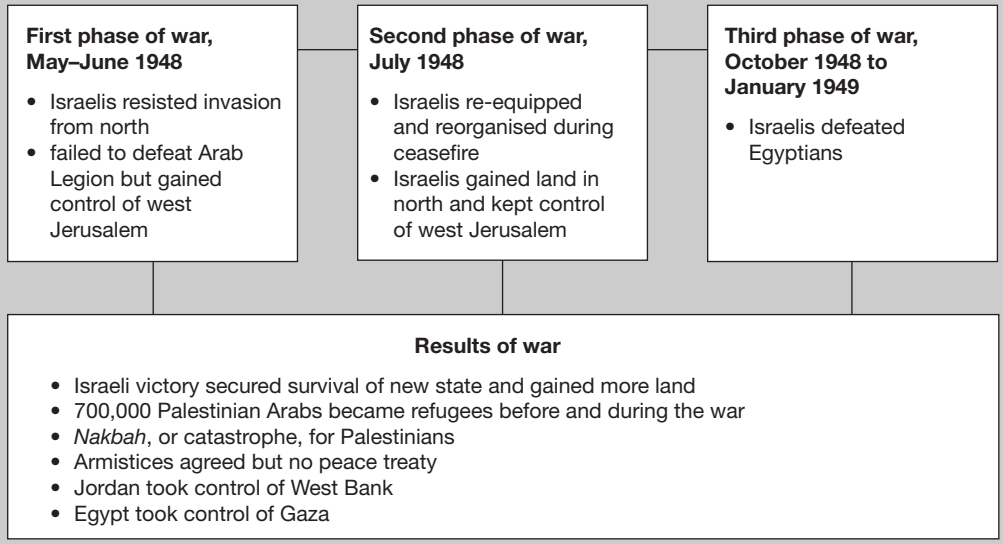
Israelis believed that time was on their side: the UN would get used to the new, expanded borders of the Israeli state and to the idea of a divided Jerusalem rather than push for the international control that they had originally envisaged for the city in the plan of 1947. In other words, Israel decided that it did not need permanent peace with the Arabs or a solution to the Palestinian refugee problem. Its priorities were now to build the new state, implement large-scale Jewish immigration and consolidate their independence.

Summary diagram: The war of 1948–9



4 | The Key Debate: How did Israel Win the War?

There is wide variation in how historians explain the outcome of the first Arab–Israeli war. The Zionist interpretation goes like this: the war was a struggle between tiny Israel and a huge Arab **coalition** made up of several armies. Israel was fighting for its own survival against Arab forces that were united in their aim of destroying the new state. Israel was the tiny David fighting against a massive Arab Goliath. Furthermore, Israel had far fewer weapons yet, against all the odds, it won the war through the heroic efforts, tenacity and courage of its people. This is the popular, heroic interpretation, which is still largely taught in Israeli schools today. It is mostly based on fact but on selectively chosen facts.

In the past 20 years historians have gained access to and analysed Israeli government documents from the time of the war. Several Israeli historians, such as Avi Shlaim and Benny Morris, have produced a new, **revisionist** interpretation of how Israel won. This new, revisionist history focuses on two main areas: on

Key terms

Coalition
A union of two or more groups for a specific purpose.

Revisionist
A 'revised' interpretation based on a critical re-examination of historical facts.